

POLITICS RIDES THE TIGER



THE FAST-UNTO-DEATH TACTIC IS A MORALE BOOSTER FOR THE DMK

The dramatic turn of events on April 27, when DMK chief M. Karunanidhi sat on a fast-unto-death even as the Sri Lankan Government decided to "end combat operations" against the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), typifies Tamil Nadu's unique brand of politics. Dravidian politicians are deft at making the right move at the right time, a quality that has helped them maintain a stronghold over the OBC votebank for the last four decades. Why else would the leader of a UPA constituent sit on a fast for ending a war that was already in its last phase?

After the DMK's nagging resulted in a visit of National Security Adviser M.K. Narayanan and Foreign Secretary Shivshankar Menon to Sri Lanka on April 24, the writing on the wall was clear for the Mahinda Rajapakse Government to rein in hostilities until elections are over in Tamil Nadu. But the octogenarian leader scripted a political masterstroke with his fast. The electoral battlelines in the state are redrawn after this "victory for Karunanidhi and the Congress". Until now AIADMK supremo J. Jayalalithaa and her allies Vaiko and Ramadoss enjoyed an upper hand on the emotional Sri Lankan Tamil issue. She is now upping the ante with the self-contradictory demand for a separate Tamil state for the ethnic minorities in Sri Lanka, knowing well the disadvantages of the ruling coalition on this front. Calling the fast 'humbug', she says, "It (fast) is a diversionary tactic to cheat the electorate."

Not able to match Jayalalithaa's new-found love for Tamil Eelam, the DMK alliance is concentrating on the "grand achievement" of stopping the killings of Tamils. But Jayalalithaa is making a dent in their campaign by exposing that it's not a ceasefire that exists in Sri Lanka but an announcement that heavy weapons won't be used.

Interestingly, none of the sides is sure if the Eelam cause will translate into votes.

by S. Senthil Kumar

Deserter on Rise

He was once her most trusted officer, but now P.L. Punia is Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati's most trenchant critic. The two were co-accused in the Taj Heritage scandal after which they parted ways. Later, the charges against Punia were dropped. Post-retirement, he joined the Congress and is now its candidate from the Barabanki reserved constituency where a tough fight is in the offing. Mayawati too has deployed all her might: ministers and the party rank and file have been asked to ensure Punia's defeat.

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



PUNIA

The Congress has also put all its resources behind him. What's more, even Priyanka Gandhi took a break from the family campaign in Rae Bareilly and Amethi to back him in Barabanki. Also, Congress chief Sonia Gandhi and son Rahul have already campaigned for him. Victory for the man would mean that all the Dalits are no longer with the BSP, since Punia himself is a Dalit. If he wins, he may well turn out to be a mascot for the Congress.

by Subhash Mishra